STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



ROLE

DELEGATION: WHAT TO HAND OVER, AND HOW FAR

How much of a manager's week others could do, why some managers hand over more than others, the five degrees of initiative, and a card for handing over one task well.

41% of knowledge workers' time went on tasks that gave them little satisfaction and that others could do well.

BIRKINSHAW & COHEN, 2013

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NO. 16 · ROLE

In this issue

Most managers were promoted because they did the work well. Delegation asks them to let someone else do it, perhaps less well at first. What to hand over, how far, and with what support: those are the questions here.

Julian Birkinshaw and Jordan Cohen found that knowledge workers spend 41% of their time on tasks others could do well. In Gallup's study of fast-growing companies, those whose CEOs had a strong talent for delegating earned more. William Oncken and Donald Wass described five degrees of initiative. Research shows what makes managers let go, and when handing over power helps people or weighs on them.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

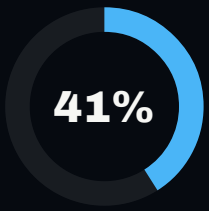
Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Work others could do

Julian Birkinshaw and Jordan Cohen asked knowledge workers to go through their tasks one by one and rate what each was worth to them and to their company.



of their time, on average, went on tasks that gave them little satisfaction and that others could do well.

01	02	03
Drop	**Delegate**	**Redesign**
Stop doing it, and see whether anyone misses it.	Someone else does it, within clear limits.	Change the task so that it takes less time.

The authors then worked with 15 executives who decided, task by task, whether to drop, delegate or redesign. On average they freed about a fifth of their time, close to one day a week, for work that mattered more.

OUR READING

Before asking who could take a task, ask whether it should exist at all. Part of the 41% should be dropped rather than passed on.

Source: Julian Birkinshaw & Jordan Cohen, Harvard Business Review, 2013

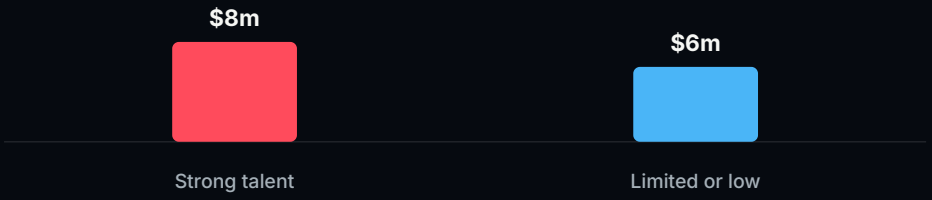
The shares are the participants' own ratings, and the group of 15 executives is small. The three choices are the authors', the descriptions the editors'.

THE NUMBERS

The CEOs who let go

In 2014 Gallup studied the talent profiles of 143 CEOs on the Inc. 500, a list of fast-growing private companies in the US, and compared those with a strong talent for delegating with those whose talent was limited or low.

AVERAGE REVENUE IN 2013, BY THE CEO'S TALENT FOR DELEGATING



33%
more revenue for the companies of CEOs with a strong talent for delegating

1 in 4
entrepreneurs with employees has a strong talent for delegating, in Gallup's wider sample

OUR READING

Fast-growing companies are not typical companies, and a link is no proof. Still, it points the same way as the 41%: a leader who keeps every task becomes the ceiling of the business.

Source: Sangeeta Bharadwaj Badal & Bryant Ott, Gallup, 2015

The talent profiles come from Gallup, which also sells an assessment of these talents. The figures describe 2013 revenue, not later growth.

THE MODEL

Who's got the monkey?

In 1974 William Oncken and Donald Wass called the next move on a problem a monkey. When a manager says “let me think about it, and I'll let you know”, the monkey jumps from the employee's back onto the manager's.

FIVE DEGREES OF INITIATIVE, FROM THE LOWEST

01	**Wait until told**	Nothing happens until the manager acts.
02	**Ask what to do**	The question comes up, the decision stays above.
03	**Recommend, then act**	The employee brings a proposal and acts on the decision.
04	**Act, then tell at once**	The decision is taken below; the manager hears straight away.
05	**Act, then report routinely**	The task belongs to the employee; the manager sees the summary.

The article sets a rule: the first two degrees are not allowed, and for each monkey manager and employee agree on degree three, four or five. HBR republished the piece as a classic in 1999, with a commentary by Stephen Covey.

OUR READING

Delegating means agreeing how far the other person may go before they need you. Handing over the task is the easy part.

Source: William Oncken Jr. & Donald L. Wass, Harvard Business Review, 1974

The five degrees are Oncken and Wass's, in our words; the descriptions are the editors'.

More in the essay When to solve it yourself and when to take it higher

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Who gets to decide

In 1986 Carrie Leana studied 44 supervisors and 198 claims adjusters in 19 offices of an insurer, and measured delegation by the amount an adjuster could settle alone.

What made supervisors delegate

- How they saw the employee
- How heavy their own workload was
- How important the decision was

What did not

- The supervisor's personality
- A general taste for sharing power

In 1999 Gary Yukl and Ping Ping Fu found that managers delegated more to people who were competent, shared the goals of the task, had worked with them longer and got on well with them. Many were reluctant to hand over important decisions, or to give an important task to someone without experience.

Across countries, Nicholas Bloom, Raffaella Sadun and John Van Reenen studied almost 4,000 firms. Those based in regions with high trust gave plant managers more say over hiring, investment, production and sales. Firms in the US and Northern Europe were the most decentralised, those in Southern Europe and Asia the most centralised.

OUR READING

In all three studies the answer lies less in the manager's character than in trust, and in what the manager knows about the person. Both can be built, one task at a time.

Sources: Carrie R. Leana, Academy of Management Journal, 1986 (via Abstract); Gary Yukl & Ping Ping Fu, Journal of Organizational Behavior, 1999 (via Abstract); Nicholas Bloom, Raffaella Sadun & John Van Reenen, Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2012

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Hours freed, load carried

Delegation can be measured twice: in the hours the manager gets back, and in how the person who takes on the task carries it.

A meta-analysis of 105 samples linked empowering leaders with better performance, more help beyond the job and more creativity. A 2016 study added a warning: some empowering behaviours also raised the strain people felt from their job. Its authors speak of two faces, one that enables and one that burdens.

1. **Log one week**
   Every task over 15 minutes, with the time it took.
2. **Drop, delegate or redesign**
   Mark each task, as Birkinshaw and Cohen suggest.
3. **Agree the degree**
   Three, four or five, and the support that comes with it.
4. **Count again in a month**
   Hours freed, and how the person feels about the load.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A MANAGER'S WEEK

Logged	45 hours in the week
Can go	12 hours, to drop or delegate
A month later	6 hours handed over, with a weekly check-in

Half the list in the first month, so that support can keep pace. The numbers are made up.

Sources: Allan Lee, Sara Willis & Amy Wei Tian, Journal of Organizational Behavior, 2018; Minyoung Cheong et al., The Leadership Quarterly, 2016 (via Abstract); Julian Birkinshaw & Jordan Cohen, Harvard Business Review, 2013

Steps and example: the editors.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The delegation card

One card for each task you hand over. Fill it in together, keep a copy each, and look at it again at the first check-in.

01 The task one sentence, starting with a verb

02 Done means the result you will both look at

03 Degree of initiative 3 recommend · 4 act and tell at once · 5 act and report

04 Limits money, time, people: where you need me

05 Support what you get from me, and who else can help

06 Check-ins dates, short, until the task is yours

Source: William Oncken Jr. & Donald L. Wass, Harvard Business Review, 1974

Proposed by the editors; the degrees of initiative follow Oncken and Wass (1974).

More in the essay 61 resellers: what wholesale taught me about trust

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Make Time for the Work That Matters
Julian Birkinshaw & Jordan Cohen, Harvard Business Review, 2013
https://hbr.org/2013/09/make-time-for-the-work-that-matters

Delegating: A Huge Management Challenge for Entrepreneurs
Sangeeta Bharadwaj Badal & Bryant Ott, Gallup, 2015
https://news.gallup.com/businessjournal/182414/delegating-huge-management-challenge-entrepreneurs.aspx

Management Time: Who's Got the Monkey?
William Oncken Jr. & Donald L. Wass, Harvard Business Review, 1974
https://hbr.org/1999/11/management-time-whos-got-the-monkey

Predictors and Consequences of Delegation
Carrie R. Leana, Academy of Management Journal, 1986 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.5465/255943

Determinants of delegation and consultation by managers
Gary Yukl & Ping Ping Fu, Journal of Organizational Behavior, 1999 · via Abstract

The Organization of Firms Across Countries
Nicholas Bloom, Raffaella Sadun & John Van Reenen, Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2012
https://ideas.repec.org/a/oup/qjecon/v127y2012i4p1663-1705.html

Empowering leadership: A meta-analytic examination of incremental contribution, mediation, and moderation
Allan Lee, Sara Willis & Amy Wei Tian, Journal of Organizational Behavior, 2018
https://doi.org/10.1002/job.2220

Two faces of empowering leadership: Enabling and burdening
Minyoung Cheong et al., The Leadership Quarterly, 2016 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.leaqua.2016.01.006

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked “via”. A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked “Our reading”.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html